Khrushchev had spent most of his life overseeing big projects and huge numbers of people. If Kennedy had prepared himself his entire life for involvement in international politics, Khrushchev was first exposed to high-level diplomacy after he turned sixty. There was also a great age difference between the two men. The Russian Revolution of 1917 was the turning point of Khrushchev's life and career. Kennedy, twenty-three years younger than his Soviet counterpart, was just born in that year.[1]

Khrushchev and his advisers, who were unhappy with the secret U-2 overflights of Soviet territory ordered by Dwight Eisenhower and his administration, first noticed John Kennedy in July 1960, when the young senator from Massachusetts won his party's nomination for president of the United States. To many in Moscow he seemed less tough than Richard Nixon, whom Khrushchev had had a chance to size up during his visit to Moscow the previous year, and more susceptible to Khrushchev's subterfuge and intimidation. Kennedy appeared to believe in a missile gap between the Soviet Union and the United States favoring the former—a notion fed not only by the Soviet success with Sputnik but also by Khrushchev's own fiery rhetoric, and one that Eisenhower's U-2 spy flights were threatening to debunk.

Khrushchev wanted to help Kennedy win the election and ordered his KGB aides to do all they could to achieve that goal. The KGB complied, setting up a number of meetings that in today's parlance would qualify as nothing less than "collusion" between Kennedy's presidential campaign and the Kremlin. Soon after Kennedy had won his party's presidential nomination, Yurii Barsukov, a KGB officer posing as a reporter for the Soviet newspaper *Izvestiia*, knocked on the office door of no less a figure than Robert Kennedy, who was running his brother's electoral campaign. He asked Robert what Moscow could do to help his brother. According to the memoirs of the chief of the KGB station in Washington, Aleksandr Feklisov, Robert drew aside the curtain covering the map of the United States with projected numbers of potential Democratic and Republican votes in every state. He invited Barsukov to write down the numbers, which the KGB officer did. Robert then suggested that the best strategy for Moscow was neutrality: once his brother won the election, better relations could be established.[2]